Laura Kurek

lkurek (at) umich.edu
laurakurek.github.io

Ph.D. Candidate | School of Information | University of Michigan

I am a final-year Ph.D. candidate who studies how state actors, particularly Russia, attempt to manipulate online information environments. My current work examines strategic attempts to influence large language models (LLMs) and retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) systems with government-aligned narratives. I combine quantitative and qualitative methods: large-scale audits of AI systems, natural language processing, quasi-experimental analysis, interviews, surveys, and qualitative coding.

Education

Ph.D., University of Michigan — *Ann Arbor, MI*
School of Information
GPA: 4.0, Research areas: Social Computing, Computational Social Science
Advisors: Dr. Ceren Budak and Dr. Eric Gilbert

B.S., Georgetown University — *Washington, DC*
Walsh School of Foreign Service
Major: Science, Technology & International Affairs
GPA: 3.86, Magna Cum Laude. Concentration: Security
Certificate: Russian, Eurasian, and Eastern European Studies

Semester Abroad, Moscow International University — *Moscow, Russia*
American Councils Advanced Russian Language and Area Studies Program (RLASP)

Publications

2026 Joshua Ashkinaze, **Laura Kurek**, Alina Faisal, Tongyuan Miao, Mariam Joseph, Ceren Budak, and Eric Gilbert. 2026. *Information Discernment in Large Language Models*. [Accepted at NeurIPS 2026]
DOI: 10.13140/RG.2.2.22199.28328/1

2026 Joshua Ashkinaze, Ruijia Guan, **Laura Kurek**, Eytan Adar, Ceren Budak, Eric Gilbert. 2026. *Seeing Like an AI: How LLMs Apply (and Misapply) Wikipedia Neutrality Norms*. Proceedings of the International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media, 20(1), 146–173. DOI: 10.1609/icwsm.v20i1.42630

2025 **Laura Kurek**, Ceren Budak, and Eric Gilbert. 2025. *Wikipedia in Wartime: Experiences of Wikipedians Maintaining Articles About the Russia-Ukraine War*. Proc. ACM Hum.-Comput. Interact. 9, 2, Article CSCW209 (April 2025), 27 pages. DOI: 10.1145/3711107

2025 **Laura Kurek**, Kevin Zheng, Eric Gilbert, and Ceren Budak. 2025. *Outsourcing an Information Operation: A Complete Dataset of Tenet Media's Podcasts on Rumble*. arXiv preprint arXiv:2503.19802

2025 **Laura Kurek**, Joshua Ashkinaze, Ceren Budak, and Eric Gilbert. 2025. *Follow Nudges without Budges: A Field Experiment on Misinformation Followers Didn't Change Follow Networks*. arXiv preprint arXiv:2512.13643

Other writings:

2024 **Laura Kurek**, Tim Harper, Aliya Bhatia, & Nathalie Marechal. 2024. *Rules of the Road: Political Advertising on Social Media in the 2024 U.S. Election*. Center for Democracy & Technology.
https://cdt.org/insights/report-rules-of-the-road-political-advertising-on-social-media-in-the-2024-u-s-election/

Under Review

2026 **Laura Kurek**, Elijah Covert, Rafael Bonilla, Eric Gilbert, and Ceren Budak. [Submitted to FAccT 2027]. *State Media at Retrieval Time: A Large-Scale Audit of Russian State-Aligned Sources in AI Chatbot Responses*
arXiv preprint: arXiv:2611.11727

Professional Experience

Center for Democracy and Technology

May 2024-Aug. 2024
Washington, DC

Technology Policy Intern | Elections & Democracy

- Co-led the production of a 40-page report on social media platforms' political advertising policies
- Conducted interviews with 7 social media companies and 5 generative AI companies
- Presented report findings to civil society groups, legislators, and industry representatives

Accenture Federal Services

Sept. 2017-July 2022
Washington, DC

Data Science Associate Manager

Dec. 2021-July 2022

- Managed research production, interfacing between federal client and internal data science teams. Defined research objectives and developed analytical methods to assess online disinformation.
- Collaborated on joint reports with allied governments. Presented findings to technical and non-technical client audiences. Published over 30 reports.

Data Science Specialist

Dec. 2020-Nov.2021

- Co-led a 9-person research team: negotiated report priorities, trained 3 new members, resolved data access issues. Published over 50 reports.
- Developed network- and account-level methods to identify and describe information campaigns.
- Led a 4-part series into a state-aligned network, assessing campaign scope and tactics.

Technology Delivery Senior Analyst

Dec. 2018-Nov.2020

- Authored social media and network analysis reports. Identified three COVID-19 disinformation campaigns. Developed a hashtag network script, advanced network visualizations, and a Django web app for topic modeling.
- Led a change management software implementation for 10 teams within a federal IT department.

Technology Delivery Analyst

Sept. 2017-Nov.2018

- Facilitated two simultaneous agency-wide software implementations using Agile development
- Managed relationships with over 40 stakeholders to standardize over 200 software requirements.
- Led 7 software training sessions for over 150 users and supported 300-person user testing.

The Fulbright U.S. Student Program

June 2016-June 2017
Perm, Russia

Fulbright English Teaching Assistant

- Led eight English-language classes weekly of 8-15 students at Perm National Research Polytechnic University, Linguistics Department.
- Taught intermediate Russian language classes to first-year international students.
- Organized a bi-monthly English conversation club. Provided faculty support translating academic papers and administrative documents from Russian to English.

Conference Presentations and Invited Talks

2026 — *The Pravda Network and Its Impact on Large Language Models.*
University of Michigan Political Communication Working Group. Sept. 18.

2026 — Featured interview on Influenced: The Tenet Media Plot, a six-part Audible series, to share findings from our dataset paper: *Outsourcing an Information Operation: A Complete Dataset of Tenet Media's Podcasts on Rumble.*

2025 — *Wikipedia in Wartime: Experiences of Wikipedians Maintaining Articles about the Russia-Ukraine War.*

- CSCW, Oct. 22. Conference proceedings paper presentation
- Wikimedia Ukraine, Sept. 23 & Nov. 15. Invited online talks with consecutive interpretation in Ukrainian.

2025 — *Who's Left to Build an Encyclopedia: Impacts on the Russian-Language Edition of Wikipedia After the Launch of a Government-Sanctioned Clone.* PolNet-PaCSS. Aug. 13.

2025 — *Follow Nudges: Targeting Inaccurate Health Information Networks via a Large-Scale Online Field Experiment*
IC2S2. July 22.

2025 — *Tenet Media: Foreign state funded content creation*
University of Michigan Political Communication Working Group. Nov. 22.

2024 — *Wikipedia in Wartime: Experiences of Wikipedians Maintaining Articles about the Russia-Ukraine War.*
Wiki Workshop 2024. June 20.

2023 — *(Not) here to build an encyclopedia: How do Wikipedians maintain articles related to the Russo-Ukrainian war?*
University of Michigan Computational Social Science Working Group. Dec. 8.

Awards

2026	Wikimedia Foundation - Wikimedia Research Fund ($45,808) University of Michigan Undergraduate Research Program Supplementary Funding ($1343.75)
2025	University of Michigan School of Information Travel Grant ($2500) University of Michigan Rackham Graduate Student Research Grant, Pre-candidacy ($1,500) ICWSM Best Reviewer Award
2024	University of Michigan Rackham Doctoral Intern Fellowship, Summer 2024 ($12,990) University of Michigan Rackham Conference Travel Grant ($900)
2023	University of Michigan School of Information Travel Grant ($500)

Professional Development and Service

2026	Reviewer, *ICWSM; Wiki Workshop; IC2S2; FAccT*
2025	Presenter, *CSCW*; Organizer, *CSCW workshop - Beyond Information: Online Culture and Information Disorder* Presenter, *PolNet-PaCSS* Presenter, *IC2S2* Reviewer, *ICWSM; Wiki Workshop; WebSci Workshop - Global Election and Information Security*
2024	Presenter, *Wiki Workshop* Reviewer, *CSCW; ICWSM workshop - International Workshop on Cyber Social Threats (CySoc)* Participant, *ICWSM workshop - Digital State Sponsored Disinformation and Propaganda Information; CRA/CCC workshop - Future of Research on Social Technologies*
2023	Participant, *ACL; CSCW* Reviewer, *ICWSM*

Mentorship

Winter 2026	Mentored 3 research assistants via the UM Undergraduate Research Opportunity Program (UROP) Mentored 1 research assistant via the UM Explore CS Research (ECSR) *My UROP mentees won the UROP Spring 2026 Research Symposium Blue Ribbon Award!*
Fall 2025	Mentored 3 research assistants via the UM Undergraduate Research Opportunity Program (UROP) Mentored 1 research assistant via the UM Explore CS Research (ECSR)
Summer 2025	Mentored 2 research assistants via the UM Michigan Institute for Data & AI in Society (MIDAS)

Teaching Experience

Winter 2026	*AI in Practice*, University of Michigan (SI 376) Graduate Student Instructor for undergraduate-level AI course
Fall 2025	*Networks*, University of Michigan (SI 608) Graduate Student Instructor for graduate-level network science course
Fall 2025	*Network Community Detection*. Guest Lecturer SI 608 Networks. October 9.
Winter 2025	*Misinformation and Disinformation Online*. Guest Lecturer SI 315 Interpersonal & Psychological Implications of Social Media. April 1.
2024-2026	**Yoga Instructor** Vinyasa & Ashtanga styles, RYT 200

Skills

I bring a wide range of quantitative and qualitative methods to my research: large-scale audits of AI systems, social network analysis, natural language processing, quasi-experimental analysis, interviews, qualitative coding, surveys, as well as data scraping and SLURM-based cluster computing capabilities. I have a solid background working with LLMs for a variety of purposes: transcribing video data using the Whisper C++ model; conducting LLM auditing and benchmarking experiments using LiteLLM and Ollama; and fine-tuning classifiers to identify persuasion techniques in news articles. I am proficient in Python, and pandas, NumPy, TensorFlow, and Transformers libraries as well as Hugging Face's repository of pre-trained models. I am accustomed to learning new methods to tackle the research question at hand.

Human Languages: Advanced Russian language proficiency [reference: CEFR C1 Level, Alta Level 10 Advanced Plus]
Computer Languages: Proficient in Python, including the libraries pandas, TensorFlow, PyTorch, and Transformers
Data Science Skills: Data cleaning, network analysis, topic modeling, social media analysis, Jupyter notebook
Other: Experiment design, semi-structured interviews, surveys